MODULE 32 · DOMAIN 6 - EVALUATION AND MONITORING

# SME feedback and aligned judges

Collecting expert judgement in a structured way, and using it to make automated judges trustworthy.

SECTION 6 of 6 EXAM WEIGHT 12% MODULE 32 of 40

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Exam boards calibrate their examiners before marking begins. **Experts need a shared rubric, and judges need to agree with the experts.**

# Feedback, or expectations?

FEEDBACK

## How good was it?

- Rates what the app produced
- Scores, categories, comments
- Subjective quality judgements
- Used to check and align judges

EXPECTATIONS

## What should it have said?

- The correct outcome, or ground truth
- Expected facts or an expected response
- Written by someone who knows
- Used by Correctness and datasets

THE TIEBREAKER

To let Correctness run, experts must supply expectations. Ratings alone are feedback, not ground truth.

# Chatting with the app, or labelling traces?

CHAT UI

## Vibe checks

- Experts talk to a deployed version
- Immediate reactions to responses
- Good before a release
- Informal and exploratory

LABELLING EXISTING TRACES

## Structured review

- Experts review chosen traces
- Answer defined questions per trace
- Can capture expectations
- Results sync into evaluation datasets

THE TIEBREAKER

For quick qualitative testing, use the chat UI. For labels that feed datasets and judges, use a labelling session.

# From traces to labelled data

01

## Choose traces

Borderline, edge cases, judge disagreements.

02

## Define schemas

The questions experts will answer.

03

## Create session

Add traces, assign experts.

04

## Experts label

In the Review App.

05

## Sync

Into a Unity Catalog evaluation dataset.

ON THE EXAM

Spend scarce expert time where judgement is actually needed, not on random samples.

# The questions experts answer

| SCHEMA | CAPTURES | EXAMPLE |
|---|---|---|
| Feedback, categorical | A choice from options | Correct, partly correct, wrong |
| Feedback, numeric | A score on a scale | Helpfulness from 1 to 5 |
| Feedback, free text | A comment | What was missing? |
| Expectation | Ground truth | The expected facts for this question |

ON THE EXAM

Choose the schema type by what you need next: feedback to check judges, expectations to run Correctness.

# Rubrics and calibration

- A **shared rubric**: each score defined in words, with an example answer for each.
- A **calibration round**: every expert labels the same small set first.
- Compare their labels, discuss disagreements, and tighten the rubric.
- Measure agreement, and recalibrate when new experts join or rules change.
- Uncalibrated experts produce noisy labels. Noisy labels cannot align a judge.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> When experts disagree with each other, the fix is a rubric and calibration, not more labels or a judge.

# Making automated judges agree with experts

- Run the judge on the **traces the experts labelled**.
- Compare verdicts. Where they differ, read the judge's **rationale**.
- Refine the judge, such as its guidelines and examples, using the expert labels.
- MLflow also supports **aligning judges** with human feedback directly.
- Re-check agreement. Once aligned, the judge scales expert judgement to every trace.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The goal is a judge that marks like your calibrated experts, at a scale no team of experts could reach.

# Users, builders and newer tools

- **End users**: thumbs up or down and comments, captured as assessments on traces.
- End-user feedback is noisy, but good for choosing traces for expert review.
- **Agent Bricks** builders take expert feedback in plain language, from module 05.
- **Review queues**, in Beta, are now recommended for new human-review workflows.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> User thumbs tell you where to look. Expert labels tell you what good looks like.

# Harbourline brings in its claims experts

01
### Rubric
Correct, partly correct, wrong, with examples.

02
### Calibrate
Six experts, the same 30 traces.

03
### Label
Borderline traces, plus expected facts.

04
### Align
Guidelines judge refined until it agrees.

05
### Scale
Aligned judge monitors every claim chat.

ON THE EXAM

Two weeks of expert time produced a judge that now reviews thousands of conversations a day.

> Five underwriting experts rate the same set of assistant answers. Their ratings differ widely: one expert's excellent is another's poor.
>
> The team wants to use their labels to align an automated judge.

## What should the team do first?

A Replace the experts with an LLM judge straight away

B Average every score and ignore the disagreements

C Ask each expert to label more traces, more quickly

D Give them a shared rubric with examples, then calibrate

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

## What should the team do first?

A Judge straight away

*Nothing trustworthy to align it with.*

B Average the scores

*Averages noise into more noise.*

C More labels, faster

*More inconsistent labels, not better ones.*

D Rubric and calibration

Makes experts agree, so their labels mean something.

THE SIGNAL

Experts disagreeing with each other is a consistency problem. The fix is a rubric and calibration, before anything else.

> A team wants to run the Correctness judge, but has no ground truth. It plans to ask policy experts for help.
>
> It is designing the labelling session.

## Which labelling schema should it use?

A. A feedback schema with a 1 to 5 helpfulness scale

B. An expectation schema capturing the expected facts

C. A free-text feedback schema for general comments

D. A thumbs-up button added to the production app

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

# Which labelling schema should it use?

A 1 to 5 helpfulness

*Feedback, not ground truth.*

B Expectation, expected facts

Exactly what Correctness reads.

C Free-text comments

*Feedback, not ground truth.*

D Thumbs-up button

*End-user feedback, not expert ground truth.*

THE SIGNAL

**Correctness needs expectations. Only an expectation schema captures them.**

> An assistant produces about 50,000 traces a week. Domain experts can spare two hours a week for review.
>
> The team must choose which traces to put into the labelling session.

## Which traces should the experts see?

A. A random sample of 500 traces from the past week

B. The 500 traces that received the highest judge scores

C. Borderline traces, edge cases and judge disagreements

D. Every trace from the most active user's recent sessions

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

## Which traces should the experts see?

A Random 500

*Mostly easy cases the judges already handle.*

B Highest judge scores

*The cases least likely to teach anything.*

C Borderline, edge, disagreements

Where human judgement adds the most. Databricks' own advice.

D One heavy user

*Narrow and unrepresentative.*

THE SIGNAL

Scarce expert time goes where judgement is needed: borderline quality, uncovered edge cases, and judge disagreements.

> After calibration, experts consistently mark some answers as too vague. The Guidelines judge passes those same answers.
>
> The team wants the judge to monitor production on its own.

## What should the team do?

A Refine the judge using the expert labels, then re-check agreement

B Trust the judge, since it is more consistent than the experts are

C Drop the judge, and rely on expert review of every trace forever

D Raise the judge's temperature so that it marks more strictly

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

## What should the team do?

**A** Refine, then re-check
Align the judge to calibrated experts, then confirm.

**B** Trust the judge
*Consistently wrong is still wrong.*

**C** Experts forever
*Cannot scale to production traffic.*

**D** Higher temperature
*Adds randomness, not strictness.*

THE SIGNAL

Calibrated experts and a judge that disagree: the experts are the reference. Align the judge to them.

# What to carry forward

- **Feedback** rates what was produced. **Expectations** are ground truth.
- Review App: **chat UI** for vibe checks, **labelling sessions** for structured labels.
- Experts first need a **shared rubric and calibration**.
- Send experts borderline traces, edge cases and judge disagreements.
- **Align judges** to calibrated experts, then let them scale.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Next: module 33 covers the metrics that pick models and fit particular scenarios.